The Inherited State

A Hypothesis About the Contemporary World

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The Claim

Most states in the world are inherited institutions. They were invented for nations and countries that no longer exist, or that never existed, and they now govern nations and countries they were not designed for. This is not a metaphor. It is a structural description.

The state is the machinery. It was built for a particular ledger, in a particular place, for a particular coalition. That ledger has changed. The machinery has not. The result is a systematic mismatch between the apparatus and the population it governs.

The mismatch explains several things that conventional analysis cannot: why so many post-colonial states are fragile; why so many "artificial" states have not dissolved; why so many nations remain divided across state borders; why so many states contain nations they do not represent; and why reform is so hard even when everyone agrees the state is failing.

The Four Types of Inheritance

States are inherited in four distinct ways. Each produces a different kind of mismatch.

The postcolonial state. The boundaries of most African, Asian, and Middle Eastern states were drawn by colonial administrators for colonial purposes. They were not designed to match existing nations, existing economies, or existing political communities. They were designed to facilitate extraction, administration, and control. When independence came, the boundaries remained. The new states inherited the machinery, but not the purposes for which it had been built. The result is a state that contains many nations, governs a country whose economy was structured for extraction rather than production, and operates an apparatus whose legitimacy was never established for the population it now governs. The coalition that sustains the government is often a narrow elite, sometimes aligned with former colonial powers, often aligned with a single ethnic group, and almost always narrower than the population.

The imperial residue. Some states are the remnants of empires: Russia after the Soviet Union, Turkey after the Ottoman Empire, Austria after the Habsburg Empire, Britain and France after their colonial empires. The state apparatus persists, but the empire that gave it purpose has dissolved. The state must now govern a population that was formerly part of a larger order, and it must do so with an apparatus that was built for a different scale and a different purpose. The result is often a state in search of an empire, or a state that cannot accept its reduced scale, or a state that governs a population with a national identity that does

not match the state's borders. The mismatch produces irredentism, revanchism, and chronic instability.

The pre-modern survivor. Some states claim continuity with pre-modern polities: China, Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia, Japan, and a few others. These states are not inherited in the same sense as the postcolonial or imperial cases; they are continuous with their own past. But the machinery they use was built for a different era: a different economy, a different population, a different set of external threats. The result is a state that must constantly adapt its apparatus to new conditions, and that often does so by layering new institutions on top of old ones without dismantling the old. The layering can produce a state that is simultaneously modern and archaic, capable and brittle, legitimate and captured.

The constructed state. Some states were built deliberately in the twentieth century: Israel, Pakistan, and the successor states of Yugoslavia, among others. These states were designed to match a nation, or to create one. The design was explicit, and the mismatch, where it exists, is a mismatch between the design and the reality. The constructed state is the clearest test of the hypothesis: where the design matched the population, the state has been durable; where it did not, the state has been fragile.

The Mismatch Hypothesis

The hypothesis can be stated formally.

Definition. A state is *matched* when its apparatus, its population, its coalition, and its nation coincide. It is *mismatched* when any of these diverge.

Four dimensions of match are relevant:

1. **Territorial match.** Does the state's territory correspond to a country that its population experiences as a homeland?
2. **National match.** Does the state govern a population that experiences itself as a single nation, or does it contain multiple nations or parts of nations?
3. **Coalitional match.** Does the coalition that sustains the government correspond to the population the government claims to serve?
4. **Functional match.** Was the state's apparatus designed for the purposes it is now called on to serve?

The hypothesis. Most states are mismatched on at least one dimension, and many are mismatched on several. The degree of mismatch is a predictor of state fragility, capture, and conflict.

The logic is straightforward. A state that does not match its population cannot govern through legitimacy; it must govern through coercion or atomization. A state that does not match its nation cannot draw on the moral resources of shared identity; it must manufacture them through education, media, and ritual. A state whose coalition does not match its population cannot serve the ledger; it must serve the coalition. A state whose apparatus was designed for a different function cannot perform its current function well; it must constantly improvise.

The mismatch is not a moral failure. It is a structural condition. It was inherited, not chosen. The states that suffer from it did not create it; they inherited it from the colonial, imperial, and pre-modern orders that preceded them.

The Consequences of Mismatch

The mismatch produces a distinctive set of pathologies.

Chronic legitimacy deficits. A mismatched state cannot draw on the legitimacy that comes from matching. It must manufacture legitimacy through ideology, through performance, through coercion, or through atomization. Each of these is expensive and fragile. The result is a state that is always one crisis away from a legitimacy collapse.

Persistent state capture. A mismatched state's coalition is almost always narrower than its population. The coalition uses the state to serve itself, and the state's mismatch makes this easier, because the excluded cannot easily organize around a shared identity or a shared grievance. The result is capture that is structural, not episodic.

Recurrent conflict. Mismatched states are more likely to experience civil war, secession, and irredentism, because the mismatch creates grievances that cannot be resolved through ordinary politics. The conflict may be ethnic, regional, religious, or ideological, but its root is the mismatch between the state and the population it governs.

Weak state capacity. A mismatched state cannot easily build capacity, because capacity requires the cooperation of the population, and the population does not cooperate with a state it does not experience as its own. The result is a state that is formally sovereign but substantively weak, unable to collect taxes, enforce laws, or deliver services.

Dependence on external support. A mismatched state often depends on external support to survive: former colonial powers, international institutions, regional hegemons, or foreign aid. The dependence is not accidental; it is structural. A state that cannot draw on its own population's resources must draw on someone else's.

Authoritarian temptations. A mismatched state is more likely to become authoritarian, because authoritarianism is a way of governing a population that does not consent. The mismatch does not cause authoritarianism, but it makes authoritarianism more likely, because the alternative—governing through consent—is harder when the state does not match the population.

What the Ledger Says

The ledger framework adds a further dimension to the mismatch hypothesis. A state is not just an apparatus; it is a ledger. It maintains relations among its population, and it maintains relations between its population and the outside world. The mismatch matters because it affects the ledger's balance.

A matched state can maintain a symbiotic ledger. Its population contributes to the state because the state serves them, and the state serves them because they are part of the same nation, the same country, the same coalition. The ledger is balanced because the interests are aligned.

A mismatched state maintains a parasitic or predatory ledger. Its population contributes to the state because they have no choice, and the state serves its coalition because that is the only way it can survive. The ledger is unbalanced because the interests are misaligned.

The mismatch is therefore not just a fact about states; it is a fact about ledgers. It determines whether the ledger is symbiotic, parasitic, or predatory. And it determines whether the ledger can be rebalanced through reform or whether it must be rebalanced through collapse.

The key insight. A mismatched state can be captured, but it cannot be reformed in the ordinary sense, because reform requires a coalition that matches the population, and the mismatched state's coalition does not. Reform requires either a change in the coalition (which is revolution) or a change in the population's relationship to the state (which is nation-building) or a change in the state's boundaries (which is secession or unification). None of these is easy. All of them are political. And all of them are what the ledger says the mismatch produces: not reform in the ordinary sense, but a continuous contestation over whether the state should exist in its current form.

The Hypothesis Applied to the Present

The hypothesis explains several features of the contemporary world that conventional analysis struggles with.

Why postcolonial states have not dissolved. The conventional expectation was that artificial states would fragment along ethnic or regional lines. Most have not. The hypothesis explains why: the state apparatus, however mismatched, is the only organized structure through which elites can access resources. The coalition that sustains the government has an interest in preserving the state, even if the state does not match the population. The state persists because the coalition persists, not because the population consents.

Why some states have dissolved. The states that have dissolved—Yugoslavia, the Soviet Union, Sudan, Czechoslovakia—are those where the mismatch was so severe that no coalition could hold the state together, or where the coalition that held it together lost its external support. The hypothesis predicts that dissolution occurs when the mismatch exceeds a threshold and the coalition that sustains the state fractures.

Why nation-building has failed. The conventional prescription for mismatched states is nation-building: creating a shared national identity that matches the state. The hypothesis explains why this has mostly failed: nation-building is expensive, slow, and often resisted by the very coalitions that benefit from the mismatch. The coalition that sustains the state has no interest in a national identity that would broaden the selectorate and dilute its hold on the state.

Why regional integration is hard. The conventional prescription for small, mismatched states is regional integration: pooling sovereignty in larger entities that can govern more effectively. The hypothesis explains why this is hard: integration requires the coalitions that sustain each state to accept a reduction in their own power, which they are rarely willing to do.

Why great-power competition persists. The conventional expectation was that globalization would reduce the importance of states. The hypothesis explains why it has not: states are the machinery through which coalitions access resources, and coalitions will not surrender that machinery.

The Normative Question

If most states are mismatched, what should be done? The framework does not prescribe. But it identifies the levers.

First, acknowledge the mismatch. The first step is to stop pretending that states are matched when they are not. The mismatch is real, and it has consequences. Acknowledging it

is the precondition for addressing it.

Second, broaden the coalition. The most direct reform is to broaden the coalition that sustains the state, so that it corresponds more closely to the population the state governs. This requires expanding voice, equalizing exit costs, and reducing the coalition's grip on the state.

Third, build matching institutions. Where the mismatch is national, the state needs institutions that accommodate multiple nations: federalism, consociationalism, autonomy, and minority rights. Where the mismatch is territorial, the state needs institutions that accommodate regional diversity. Where the mismatch is functional, the state needs institutions that are designed for the purposes it actually serves, not the purposes it was inherited with.

Fourth, accept that some mismatches cannot be resolved within the current state. Some mismatches are so severe that they can only be resolved by changing the state's boundaries: through secession, unification, or partition. The framework does not say this is always desirable; it says it is sometimes necessary, and that pretending otherwise does not make the mismatch go away.

Fifth, recognize that reform is political, not technical. The mismatch cannot be resolved by technocratic fixes. It requires a contestation of the ledger, and contestation is political. The question is not "what is the right policy?" The question is "whose state is this, and for whom?" And that question has no technical answer.

A Closing Observation

The inherited state is one of the great facts of the contemporary world, and it is one of the least discussed.

We talk about failed states, fragile states, captured states, authoritarian states, democratic states. But we rarely talk about the fact that most states were not designed for the populations they now govern, and that this mismatch is structural, not incidental.

The ledger framework makes the mismatch visible. It says: look at the state, look at the population, look at the coalition, look at the nation, and ask whether they match. The answer will tell you more about the state's trajectory than any label, any ideology, any constitutional form.

The states that match their populations can govern through consent. The states that do not must govern through coercion, atomization, or capture. The states that match their nations can draw on the moral resources of shared identity. The states that do not must manufacture them. The states whose coalitions match their populations can serve the ledger. The states whose coalitions do not must serve the coalition.

Most states do not match. They are inherited. They were built for other purposes, in other eras, by other coalitions. They persist because the coalitions that sustain them have an interest in their persistence, not because the populations they govern experience them as their own.

This is not a counsel of despair. It is a counsel of realism. The mismatch is real, and it can be addressed. But it cannot be addressed by pretending it does not exist. It must be named, analyzed, and contested. And that is what the ledger framework allows us to do.

The question is always the same: whose state is this, and for whom? For most states in the world, the answer is: not the population's, and not for them.